

SAMĀDHI WATER REPENTANCE

SCROLL THREE PRACTICE GUIDE

Karmic results, dedication and memorial practice explained

Triple Gem • realms • Pure Land • memorial altar

Prepared by Daniel Franjkovic

daniel.franjkovic@outlook.com.au

More Buddhist terms: www.fgsitc.org/glossary/

Open the project

Scroll Three Practice Companion

Karmic results, dedication and memorial practice explained

Prepared by
Daniel Franjkovic
daniel.franjkovic@outlook.com.au

Source edition
Fo Guang Shan Hsi Lai Temple, electronic edition 3.0, 2022
English translation by Andrew Nguy and Raymond Kong
Covers Scroll Three

Further glossary
www.fgsitc.org/glossary/

This independent educational companion explains the official English liturgy without reproducing it. The source PDFs remain copyrighted by Fo Guang Shan Hsi Lai Temple and are linked in the references.

Designed for clear A4 printing. Complete collection edition, August 2026.

Contents

Part	Contents
1	Scroll Three
2	References

PDF bookmarks provide direct navigation to every major section.



Scroll Three

What each part is doing and why

Scroll Three completes the Water Repentance. It examines damaged relationships with the Buddha, Dharma and Sangha, turns to the painful results of karma, dedicates the practice to all beings and closes with memorial and Pure Land rites.

This guide explains the English translation without reproducing the full liturgy. Page numbers refer to Fo Guang Shan Hsi Lai Temple's 2022 electronic edition.

Before beginning

- Scroll Three assumes the work of Scrolls One and Two. Affliction has been recognised, harmful actions confessed and positive vows established.
- Its descriptions of hells and rebirth belong to traditional Buddhist moral cosmology and ritual imagery. Some Buddhists read the realms primarily as objective rebirth destinations, some also use them as descriptions of states of mind, and many allow both levels.
- The aim of the severe imagery is urgency followed by transformation. The vows repeatedly turn prisons into Pure Lands, weapons into jewels and suffering into conditions for awakening.
- The memorial altar extends the practice to deceased people and other beings through recitation, offerings and dedication of merit.

Guide to Scroll Three

1. Lamp's Radiant Light Praise

Source page 3

What is happening?

The assembly bows and praises a lamp whose light reaches dark paths. The verse names King Yama and Dīpaṃkara Buddha.

Why is it done?

Light represents awareness and wisdom. At the beginning of the final scroll, the lamp announces that even the darkest karmic condition can be seen clearly and approached through practice.

Beginner notes

- King Yama is a traditional judge or administrator associated with the realms of the dead. He is not a creator god or an eternal ruler of damnation.
- Dīpaṃkara, whose name is associated with lamp light, is a Buddha of the distant past. Traditional accounts say that he predicted a future Buddhahood for the person who would become Śākyamuni.
- Lamps offered at an altar commonly symbolise the wish that wisdom dispel ignorance.

2. Prayer of Entering Repentance

Source pages 4-7

What is happening?

The third session is opened through refuge, prostration and the transformation of body, speech and mind. Buddhas, bodhisattvas, sages and protective beings are invited to witness the practice.

Why does the prayer repeat the number three?

The language links the third scroll with several Buddhist triads: the three karmas of body, speech and mind; the three vehicles; the three realms; the three bodies of a Buddha; and the threefold repetition of refuge and request.

Beginner notes

- The three vehicles are paths associated with disciples, solitary buddhas and bodhisattvas. Mahāyāna texts often gather them within the ultimate aim of Buddhahood.
- The three bodies describe Buddhahood as truth or reality, transcendent enjoyment and compassionate manifestation.
- The three realms are the desire, form and formless realms within saṃsāra.
- The four immeasurables are loving-kindness, compassion, appreciative joy and equanimity.

3. Repairing the Relationship with the Triple Gem

Source pages 8-13

What is happening?

The assembly confesses disrespect towards Buddha images, stupas and temples; careless handling or distortion of scriptures; contempt for monastics and teachers; misuse of religious identity; and neglect of sacred places.

Why does material care matter?

Buddhist statues, books and buildings are not creator gods. They are supports for memory, teaching and community. Caring for them trains gratitude and preserves access to the Dharma for others.

The three relationships

Refuge	What can be damaged	Positive repair
Buddha	Disrespect, destruction or reducing awakening to an object of status	Reverence for awakening and care for its images
Dharma	Distorting, neglecting, withholding or using teachings for fame	Accurate study, preservation and sincere practice

Refuge	What can be damaged	Positive repair
Sangha	Contempt, exploitation, false representation or disruption	Respect, ethical support and harmonious community

Six points of reverent harmony

The vows refer to a community living harmoniously through shared bodily conduct, speech, intention, ethical discipline, understanding and use of resources. The precise wording varies across Buddhist sources, but the purpose is stable: practise together without rivalry and misuse.

> Why this matters Refuge is a lived relationship. Respect for the Triple Gem is shown through how teachings are handled, how communities are treated and whether practice is used honestly.

4. Remorse, Shame and Everyday Conduct

Source pages 14-19

What is happening?

The text identifies remorse and shame as two protective qualities, then confesses arrogance, intoxication, overconsumption, improper livelihood, misuse of offerings, jealousy and neglect of practice.

What do remorse and shame mean here?

- Remorse recognises that one's own harmful action should not be repeated.
- Moral shame recognises the dignity of oneself and others and refuses to encourage wrongdoing.

They are not permanent self-condemnation. They are the capacity to feel an ethical boundary and change direction.

Five pungent vegetables

Some East Asian monastic traditions avoid garlic, onions and related pungent plants, especially in periods of formal practice. Traditional explanations link their smell or stimulating effect with ritual purity and mental agitation. This discipline is distinct from the general lay precepts.

Improper livelihood

The passage applies ethics to earning and receiving resources. It includes dealing in animals for slaughter, intoxicants, exploitation through debt and accepting religious support without living up to the responsibilities attached to it.

The positive vow

The assembly vows to be kind, loyal, filial, humble, patient and careful with the senses and three karmas. Repentance is again completed by describing the conduct that should replace the fault.

5. Resultative Obstructions and Impermanence

Source pages 20-23

What is happening?

After afflictive and karmic obstructions, the liturgy turns to resultative obstructions, the painful conditions in which the effects of karma mature.

Why does it speak so urgently about death?

The passage stresses that youth, wealth, status and even refined meditation do not make conditioned life permanent. The next breath is not guaranteed. Practice should begin while choice and support are available.

The story of a deva

The text recalls a celestial being whose signs of approaching death are reversed through repentance. The story supports the ritual claim that sincere reform and wholesome conditions can alter the direction of a life.

Subhadra and Udrakarāmaputra

The example of a highly accomplished meditator later falling into an animal birth warns that concentration alone is not final liberation. Temporary mastery of a subtle state is not the same as ending ignorance and rebirth.

> In simple terms Do not confuse a comfortable condition, high status or unusual meditation experience with complete freedom.

6. Avīci and the Hell Realms

Source pages 24-29

What is happening?

The text gives an elaborate description of Avīci and names many other hot, cold and specialised hells. The images include iron walls, fire, weapons, predatory beings and repeated injury.

What is Avīci?

Avīci means "without interval". It is traditionally described as a hell of uninterrupted suffering produced by extremely destructive karma. It is not eternal in the sense of an unending divine sentence, but its duration is depicted as immense.

How can the imagery be understood?

Recognised Buddhist readings include:

- Cosmological: hells are possible rebirth destinations within saṃsāra.
- Psychological: hatred, terror and compulsive violence can create hell-like experience in the present.
- Ritual and ethical: the extreme images break complacency and turn the mind away from cruelty.

These readings can overlap. The liturgy itself treats the realms as karmic realities while also using them as moral images.

The decisive movement

The confession does not delight in punishment. Its vow is that Avīci become a Pure Land, instruments of torture become sources of peace and every suffering being encounter liberation.

7. Animals, Hungry Ghosts, Spirits and Asuras

Source pages 30-36

What is happening?

After another Buddha-name litany, the text considers painful results associated with non-human realms.

Realm or being	Central condition in the passage	Practice response
Animals	Ignorance, fear, confinement, labour and being harmed by others	Wisdom, freedom and protection of life
Hungry ghosts	Insatiable hunger and thirst	Generosity, contentment and the liberating "sweet dew" of Dharma
Troubled spirits	Distortion, insecurity and harmful livelihood	Honesty, beauty of character and benefit to others
Asuras	Conflict, jealousy and aggressive competition	Equanimity, non-deception and peace

Contentment

The section begins by contrasting desire with contentment. A person may possess little and still experience ease, or live in luxury and remain dissatisfied. Contentment does not mean refusing improvement. It means freedom from the belief that one more possession will finally make grasping secure.

Returning by vow

The assembly vows not to fall helplessly into the lower realms, while allowing for compassionate return by a bodhisattva who deliberately enters difficult conditions to help beings.

8. Residual Results Among Humans and Devas

Source pages 37-40

What is happening?

The confession lists illness, conflict, separation, poverty, disaster, fear, failed relationships and many other forms of vulnerability in human and heavenly lives.

What does "residual result" mean?

It is a remaining effect or tendency after a stronger karmic result has matured. The concept explains why difficulty can continue even within a comparatively fortunate rebirth.

Why include heavenly lives?

Deva existence is pleasurable but impermanent. When its supporting karma is exhausted, decline and rebirth continue. This is why the Buddhist goal is liberation, not simply heaven.

How to read the catalogue

The list is a communal confession within a traditional karmic worldview. Its practice purpose is compassion and urgency, not the confident diagnosis of any particular person's misfortune.

9. Universal Vows and Dedication

Source pages 41-43

What is happening?

The merits of repenting the three obstructions are dedicated to all beings. The assembly wishes for present safety, sufficient food and clothing, faith in the Triple Gem, rebirth in Amitābha's Pure Land and progress towards Buddhahood.

Pure Land and liberation

Sukhāvatī is sought as an exceptionally supportive field for hearing the Dharma and advancing without ordinary obstacles. It is not merely a reward of celestial pleasure. Its purpose is the completion of the path for the benefit of beings.

Endless dedication

The formula that dedication will continue until space, beings, karma and affliction end echoes Samantabhadra's vast vows. Because these fields are treated as immeasurable, the commitment is effectively without limit.

10. Final Mantra and Prayer of Exiting Repentance

Source pages 43-46

What is happening?

The Seven Buddhas mantra seals the main repentance. The assembly then reviews the whole service: circumambulation, sūtra and mantra recitation, confession, prostration, Buddha-name chanting and offerings.

Why review the actions?

The review gathers a long multi-session ritual into one field of merit. It also acknowledges that outward completion is not enough if the confession was insincere, so the assembly asks to repent once more.

Important references

- Infinite Life Tathāgata is Amitāyus, the long-life aspect or name of Amitābha.
- The Lotus Treasury is a vast purified cosmos associated with Mahāyāna vision.
- The Dragon Flower assemblies are future teaching assemblies under Maitreya Buddha.
- The four kindnesses commonly include parents, sentient beings, rulers or society, and the Triple Gem. Lists vary by source.

11. Memorial Altar Dedication

Source pages 47-51

What is happening?

The service turns explicitly towards deceased beings. It invokes Amitābha, recites the Heart Sūtra and several dhāraṇīs, transforms food and water symbolically into boundless offerings, dedicates merit and respectfully sends off the sacred assembly.

Why Amitābha?

Amitābha is invoked as the guide and receiver of the Western Pure Land. In East Asian memorial practice, his name expresses the wish that deceased beings encounter clarity, support and a favourable rebirth in Sukhāvatī.

Why the Heart Sūtra?

The Heart Sūtra teaches that the five aggregates and all phenomena are empty of independent, permanent essence. In a memorial setting, this wisdom loosens fearful attachment to fixed identity while compassion continues to care for the deceased.

The four dhāraṇī functions

Recitation	Ritual purpose
Rebirth in the Pure Land Dhāraṇī	Supports aspiration towards Amitābha's Pure Land.
Transformation of Food Dhāraṇī	Imagines a limited offering becoming sufficient for innumerable beings.
Sweet Dew Dhāraṇī	Offers cooling nourishment and Dharma relief to thirsty beings.
Universal Offering Dhāraṇī	Extends the offering throughout the whole Dharma realm.

Dhāraṇī syllables should be learned from the temple's liturgical text and sound model rather than reconstructed from English spelling.

Sending off the sacred

The rite concludes by thanking and respectfully releasing the invoked assembly. This gives a clear boundary to the ritual encounter.

12. Venerable Master Hsing Yun's Prayer

Source pages 52-58

What is happening?

A modern prayer restates the Water Repentance in direct language. It confesses greed, pride, hatred, wrong views and carelessness, then uses memorable images of dams, ploughs, light and cleansing water.

Why is it important?

The prayer connects the medieval liturgy with Fo Guang Shan's Humanistic Buddhist emphasis on daily life. Repentance is applied to relationships, society, confidence, compassion and practical service.

Images to remember

- Dams of repentance stop the flood of desire.
- Ploughs of repentance level mountains of pride.
- Clear pearls purify confused or defiled awareness.
- Dharma water cleanses knots of karmic enmity.

The final pathway

The prayer asks practitioners to use kindness and compassion to beautify life, joy and equanimity to improve society, precepts and meditation to regulate conduct, and wisdom to purify the mind. It is a concise programme for carrying the ritual into ordinary action.

13. Final Verse of Dedication

Source page 58

What is happening?

The complete three-scroll practice ends by dedicating its benefit throughout all Dharma realms. Chan, Pure Land, ethical discipline and patient equality appear together.

What does this reveal about the tradition?

The liturgy is not limited to one narrow method. It brings together meditation, Buddha-name recollection, precepts, repentance, mantra, wisdom and universal vows within a Chinese Mahāyāna and Fo Guang Shan setting.

Scroll Three in one view

Movement	Purpose
Lamp and entry	Bring wisdom into the final session.
Triple Gem confession	Repair relationships with awakening, teaching and community.
Resultative obstruction	Face impermanence and the consequences of karma.
Realms of suffering	Turn fear and cruelty towards compassionate liberation.
Universal dedication	Share every benefit with all beings.
Memorial altar	Support the deceased through wisdom, offering and Pure Land aspiration.
Hsing Yun prayer	Carry repentance into daily life and society.

Scroll Three's final message is transformation. Nothing harmful is denied, but no being is reduced forever to a harmful action or painful realm. Confession becomes vow, fear becomes urgency, offering becomes boundless and the merit of practice is released for the welfare and awakening of all.



References

Sources and editorial limits

Links were checked on 22 August 2026. The guide paraphrases its copyrighted source and uses short labels only where necessary for explanation.

Source liturgy

- Fo Guang Shan Hsi Lai Temple. Liturgy of the Samādhi Water Repentance of Kindness and Compassion: Scroll One. Electronic edition 3.0, 2022. Main source for the Scroll One guide and page map.
- Fo Guang Shan Hsi Lai Temple. Scroll Two. Electronic edition 3.0, 2022. Main source for the Scroll Two guide and page map.
- Fo Guang Shan Hsi Lai Temple. Scroll Three. Electronic edition 3.0, 2022. Main source for the Scroll Three guide, memorial rites and final prayer.

The PDFs credit Andrew Nguy and Raymond Kong as translators, editors and graphic designers. They state that reproduction requires the publisher's permission except for fair use. The original PDFs are therefore not included in this repository.

Fo Guang Shan and Hsi Lai Temple resources

- Fo Guang Shan International Translation Center. Buddhist Glossary. Primary terminology cross-check.
- Fo Guang Shan International Translation Center. The Heart Sūtra. Five aggregates, emptiness and Avalokiteśvara.
- Fo Guang Shan International Translation Center. The Amitabha Sutra. Amitābha, Sukhāvatī and Pure Land practice.
- Fo Guang Shan International Translation Center. The Forty-Eight Vows of Amitabha Buddha. Dharmākara's vows and Pure Land aspiration.

- Fo Guang Shan International Translation Center. Master's Advice on Daily Practice. Refuge, prostration, offerings, chanting and dedication.
- Fo Guang Shan International Translation Center. Visiting a Buddhist Temple. Temple etiquette and ritual actions.
- Fo Guang Shan International Translation Center. The Buddhist Perspective on Life and Destiny. Karma, repentance and the image of Dharma water.
- Fo Guang Shan. Samantabhadra Bodhisattva Shrine. White elephant, six tusks, vows and practice.
- Fo Guang Shan. Objectives of Fo Guang Shan. Humanistic Buddhist institutional context.

Canonical and translation sources

- BDK America. The Mahayana Sutra of Previous Lives and Contemplation of the Mind-ground. Confession, shame, vows and repentance at phenomenal and principle levels.
- BDK America. A Forest of Pearls from the Dharma Garden, volume 1. Traditional cosmology and six-realm context.
- SuttaCentral. Aṅguttara Nikāya 6.63, Penetrative. Early Buddhist definition of karma through intention.
- SuttaCentral. Saṃyutta Nikāya 12.2, Analysis of Dependent Origination. The twelve links.

Historical and academic studies

- De Hong. A Study and Translation of The Compassionate Water Repentance Ritual. University of the West, 2011. Main historical study used for the development of the ritual, uncertain authorship, traditional Wuda narrative, and phenomenal and principle repentance.
- Wendi L. Adamek. "Addressing the Mind: Developments in the Culture of Confession in Sui-Tang China". Journal of Chinese Buddhist Studies 28, 2015, pp. 117-152. Chinese Buddhist confession and repentance context.
- Sun He-Rong. "A Study on the Purification of Defilements in The Compassion-Samadhi-Water-Repentance". Nanhua University, 2024. Modern study of the first scroll's defilement lists and practice.
- Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy. Japanese Pure Land Philosophy. Used cautiously for the broader doctrinal distinction between Pure Land aspiration and ordinary saṃsāric heaven. The companion does not treat the Chinese liturgy as a Japanese sectarian text.

Artwork records

Each image caption in FIGURES.md gives its direct museum or Wikimedia source and licence. Key collection records include:

- The Metropolitan Museum of Art: Avalokiteśvara, Samantabhadra, Mahāsthāmaprāpta and Ksitigarbha.
- Wikimedia Commons: Śākyamuni, Vairocana, Amitābha, Dīpamkara.JPG), Maitreya, Medicine Master Buddha_-_Google_Art_Project.jpg), Prabhūtaratna and Śākyamuni.jpg) and the Seven Buddhas.jpg).

Editorial limits

- Sanskrit names and terms are normalised only where the identification is secure. The source spelling remains the reference for chanting.
- English pronunciation cues are approximations, not International Phonetic Alphabet transcriptions.
- Vietnamese names are a recognition aid only. Tone and regional pronunciation should be learned from a Vietnamese speaker or temple.
- Literal and psychological interpretations of cosmological realms are both identified as recognised approaches. The guide does not claim that all Buddhist traditions interpret them in the same way.
- The traditional Wuda narrative is explained respectfully and distinguished from historical verification.

May the benefit of this work support understanding, compassionate reform and the awakening of all beings.

For further Buddhist terminology

www.fgsitc.org/glossary/